

If you are going to choose No. 1 and let your money just sit, you should at least put it in a place where the interest earned is working for you. By investing your money in a low- or zero-interest earning account (as the majority of lottery winners do), it is the same as putting the money under your mattress.

What's the right way to handle this windfall? In order to avoid becoming a statistic and ending up with a lot of toys but no real increase in net worth, a financial plan needs to be designed to allocate your money. Take time to create this plan and get input from everyone in the family. Families tend to spend more time discussing the weather (something we can't change) than we do discussing our financial situation (something we can change).

Your financial plan should be developed with your input and the assistance of a qualified financial planner. Once the plan is decided upon, it is a good idea to continue to have a professional monitor your account and give you continual advice. When choosing a financial planner, make sure you also trust this person.

Problems can result if you entrust your finances to someone who is not looking after your best interests, or, in the worst-case scenario, is stealing from you. Child star Gary Coleman, one of the highest paid television child actors of his era, sued his adoptive parents for mishandling his funds. He claimed they had misappropriated money from commissions, salaries, fees, and his pension fund. The case was not settled until 1993, with Coleman being awarded 1.3 million dollars from his parents. Coleman said that this money was quickly devoured by lawyer's fees and poor investments. Therefore, it is important to find a financial planner you can trust and whose interest in your finances is impartial.

Once you are comfortable with your choice of a financial

